

Chapter 174-1

Two spring rains had fallen, and the weather was gradually warming up.

Yu Wan had already given birth. It was a baby boy, named Liang Jia.

Liang Shi had visited her a few times, though she couldn't stay too long each time.

Yu Wan always had a confinement nanny¹ and her mother by her side. Liang Xinzhou had to work during the day, and also had to handle Yu Wan's share of work. He was so busy he was like a spinning top, and had lost quite a bit of weight.

Qiu Zimin, however, rarely went to the hospital. She only bought some nutritional supplements for Yu Wan.

One time when Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu went to visit, they overheard Yu Wan's mother complaining, "She used to be a decent person. How has she become more unreasonable with age? Even if you and Xinzhou have moved out, the grandson she just gave birth to is still part of their family, isn't he? It's one thing that she's not coming to help with your postpartum recovery, but she barely even visits. Really... I think her brain has gone bad."

"Mom..." Yu Wan patted her mother's hand, signaling her to stop talking.

Yu Wan's mother was still angry, but out of consideration for her daughter's dignity and mood, she didn't continue.

Right after giving birth, one lacks sleep the most, and the body hasn't recovered yet. When Liang Shi visited, she would occasionally help watch the baby. This little one was very well-behaved—whenever Liang Shi held him, he would be amused into giggles, and would fall asleep shortly after.

This gave Yu Wan a chance to rest.

Once Yu Wan fell asleep, Liang Shi felt it wasn't appropriate to stay any longer, so she got up to leave.

Life continued on. Xu Qingzhu had strong reactions during the early stages of pregnancy. Especially when Liang Shi had just returned to her side, she would often wake up in the middle of the night to dry heave, and had to eat something sour to suppress it.

Once she passed the three-month mark, things were fine.

Moreover, because Xu Qingzhu was thin, her belly showed relatively slowly.

But it was true that she could eat more than before.

Perhaps because she was carrying twins, she now had to eat five meals a day. She would occasionally joke that she was like a Taotie.²

Liang Shi would smile and go along with her words: "It's clearly the two in your belly who are like Taotie."

Xu Qingzhu rubbed her belly. "Did you hear that? Your mom says you two are like Taotie."

Liang Shi: "...You're even tattling on me?"

"Of course." Xu Qingzhu smiled lightly. "Otherwise, what if they don't like me in the future?"

Liang Shi: "?"

"You mean it's okay for them not to like me?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu pursed her lips: "It's best if they don't like you more than they like me."

Liang Shi: "....."

At that moment, Liang Shi was sitting across from her, propping her chin with her hand as she looked at her. Outside the restaurant's huge floor-to-ceiling windows, people came and went.

"You just think everyone has to like you, don't you?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded, then shook her head: "Yes and no."

After a slight pause, she added: "It's enough as long as you like me."

"What about them?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu thought for a moment: "I want to be the person who loves you the most, so they can't like you more than I do."

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi gently flicked her nose. "You, honestly."

Xu Qingzhu smiled tenderly.

She sat with her back to the light, sunlight falling on her, light and shadow dancing on her cheeks—serene and beautiful.

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu didn't seem to have much difficulty accepting the arrival of these two children.

Even though these two children were unexpected.

Both of them had remarkably good acceptance. Perhaps it was because they loved each other so much that they naturally accepted the fruits of their love.

Liang Shi had never thought she would have her own children in this lifetime. Based on the scientific development where she came from, she probably wouldn't have been able to wait for it in her entire life.

But now it had happened so easily.

Unexpected, yet delightful.

After Xu Qingzhu became pregnant, she continued to be busy with work. It's just that as the months progressed, the time she could spend sitting and working each day became limited. Fortunately, she had started preparing during the early stages of pregnancy, so the company wasn't in chaos now.

Most importantly, Lu Jiayi was there to help.

Although Lu Jiayi didn't directly interfere with Minghui's affairs, she was fully responsible for the parts where the two of them collaborated, and Xu Qingzhu completely trusted her abilities.

Worth mentioning was that Lu Jiayi's wedding date was quickly set—in early summer, the first half of July.

When Lu Jiayi handed the invitation to Liang Shi, Liang Shi was quite surprised.

After thinking about it, she could understand.

Lu Jiayi had originally come to Haizhou to find a marriage alliance partner. In the end, she didn't find a marriage partner but found an excellent business partner instead, which was already enough for her.

At this point, if she wanted to consolidate her position in the Lu family and obtain the Lu family's inheritance rights among all the covetous candidates, finding a marriage alliance partner for herself would be ideal.

Apart from losing the freedom to marry for love, there were no other losses.

Obviously, Lu Jiayi was someone who didn't care about the freedom of marriage. She was very goal-oriented and not greedy—once she decided on career, she could sacrifice love.

Liang Shi also admired this kind of determined person.

Her fiancée Fu You was indeed very charming. To thank her for helping find the mastermind behind the hot search incident, Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu treated Lu Jiayi and Fu You to a meal of Huaiyang cuisine.³

That day, Fu You wore a green hoodie, white jeans, and had wavy blue-green hair. She didn't look at all like an IT top student.

Completely different style from Lu Jiayi's white shirt and black dress pants.

Fu You had a great figure—literally a great figure.

No flaws from any angle. Her individual features were actually quite ordinary when separated, but combined together, they had a uniquely charming beauty.

The moment she saw Liang Shi, she smiled and teased: "Much prettier than in the shows."

Liang Shi smiled: "You flatter me."

"Have a seat." Fu You directly took charge as if she were the host. "I've been starving all day. Can I order whatever I want?"

"Yes," Liang Shi said. "Order whatever you want to eat."

She wasn't shy either. After ordering what she wanted, she handed the menu to Xu Qingzhu. "Little sister, your turn."

Xu Qingzhu added a few more dishes.

It actually wasn't a gathering of very familiar people, but Fu You had the ability to make everyone comfortable within just a few sentences. When chatting with Liang Shi, she specifically asked about areas Liang Shi was familiar with, such as acting, variety shows, and even asked about screenwriting.

Liang Shi answered everything, while Xu Qingzhu kept sneaking glances at Fu You.

Liang Shi pinched her under the table, and Xu Qingzhu gave her a sidelong glance.

Later during the meal, Xu Qingzhu quietly asked Liang Shi: "I wasn't lying to you, was I? She's very charming."

Liang Shi: "....."

She did admire Fu You, but after seeing how much Xu Qingzhu admired her, she became a little less admiring.

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1. "月嫂" (yuè sǎo) - A confinement nanny or postpartum care specialist. In Chinese culture, the postpartum period (called "坐月子" or "sitting the month") is traditionally a time when new mothers rest and recover for about a month, with strict guidelines about diet, activity, and care. Confinement nannies are professionals hired to help care for both the mother and newborn during this period. ↵
 2. Taotie (饕餮) - A mythical creature from ancient Chinese mythology known for its insatiable appetite and gluttony. It's often depicted on ancient bronze vessels and is one of the "Four Fiends" in Chinese mythology. The term is commonly used to describe someone with a voracious appetite. ↵
 3. Huaiyang cuisine (淮揚菜) - One of the four major traditional Chinese cuisines, originating from the Huai'an and Yangzhou regions of Jiangsu province. It's known for its delicate flavors, emphasis on freshness, and refined cooking techniques. ↵

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After this meal ended, Xu Qingzhu asked Fu You for her contact information.

Liang Shi smiled helplessly from the side.

Fu You was also a science student with a straightforward mind. She spoke without beating around the bush, very different from Lu Jiayi.

At one point, she mentioned the matter of Liang Shi previously wanting to divorce Xu Qingzhu, and asked very directly: "Your relationship is so good—why did you try to get divorced before?"

As a result, Lu Jiayi kicked her under the table. She frowned and looked at Lu Jiayi: "Why did you kick me?"

Lu Jiayi then tried to hold her hand, but she shrank back into the corner. "You just kicked me, don't hold my hand."

Lu Jiayi: "....."

Liang Shi glossed over the topic with a vague response.

Afterwards, while waiting for Xu Qingzhu and Fu You, Liang Shi stood there chatting with Lu Jiayi. "Fu You isn't the type you described before, is she? She's quite innocent."

Lu Jiayi: ".....You can know a person's face but not their heart."¹

Liang Shi: "?"

"Could it be that you're biased against her?" Liang Shi asked.

Lu Jiayi: "....."

Lu Jiayi had an expression that said it was hard to explain in a few words, as if to say—you simply don't understand.

"Regardless, congratulations on getting married," Liang Shi said. "I hope you two will be happy."

Lu Jiayi's expression softened slightly: "Mm, we probably will."

For her, obtaining the Lu family's inheritance rights was the greatest happiness.

And marrying Fu You would bring her one step closer to that goal.

So... if Fu You was ruthless, so be it.

If she had no moral compass, so be it. Anyway, the two of them were now tied to the same boat, and Fu You couldn't possibly harm her.

Fu You was very innocent in some matters, but in matters where she liked to use her brain, she could be described as extremely cunning.

Compared to Lu Jiayi, she was just as capable.

And her moral baseline was much lower than Lu Jiayi's.

Lu Jiayi felt that even if she wasn't a true gentleman, she was at least a hypocritical one who still adhered to some inviolable moral boundaries. But Fu You didn't.

Perhaps it was related to her upbringing—Fu You had grown up wild.

As long as she could survive, or as long as it put her in an advantageous position, she could become countless different versions of herself in countless people's eyes.

Ever-changing.

What Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu saw today was just an innocent, naive girl who only knew how to deal with code.

But Lu Jiayi had seen her ruthless side back in the capital—raising her hand to snap someone's fingers, then stomping and breaking two of their ribs, only to turn around and smile at her as if nothing had happened, asking what she wanted to eat for dinner.

When she first witnessed that scene, it truly overturned Lu Jiayi's worldview.

Even though she knew Fu You had the notorious nickname "Knockoff Medusa" in the capital, she still chose to enter into a marriage alliance for the sake of the power behind her.

But that day, she had her first thoughts of backing out.

However, later on, it was Fu You who stood by her side and helped her break the leg bones of the assassins sent by her youngest brother to kill her.

Even though afterwards Fu You looked at her with contempt and said: "Future wife, you're kind of weak."

Lu Jiayi still chose to continue with the marriage alliance, and even moved up the wedding date.

If Liang Shi and the others wanted to think this way now, then let them think so.

After all, they would eventually have to return to the capital.

Once the matters in Haizhou were settled, they would still have to go back to the capital to clean up the mess.

The Lu family couldn't possibly give anything to nobodies with no status.

1. "知人知面不知心" is a Chinese proverb meaning "you can know someone's face but not their heart"—essentially, you can never truly know what someone is thinking or what they're really like on the inside just from outward appearances. ⇐

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Liang Shi had no idea about all the twists and turns between them.

On the contrary, she and Xu Qingzhu both agreed that Lu Jiayi and Fu You were a good match.

They both felt that Lu Jiayi was someone with deep thoughts and was profit-driven, so it was better to match her with an innocent, naive girl who didn't know the ways of the world.

It was fortunate that Lu Jiayi didn't know this.

Otherwise, she would have coughed up blood.

This spring was a vibrant spring.

Everything was growing toward the sun, beautiful beyond words.

Liang Shi had completely adapted to the pace of life here. After finishing filming "Lingering Light," she seamlessly joined another production for that period drama. Although she was the second female lead, the character's personality was very appealing to fans.

Then came the enthusiastic response after "Let's Go Right Now" aired.

Especially after netizens learned that Liang Shi and Liang Xinran were the true and fake heiresses, they examined that show under a microscope. But the two really didn't have much interaction—Liang Shi barely spoke to Liang Xinran on the show.

Because of Liang Xinzhou's intervention, the production team cut many of Liang Shi's scenes.

This helped avoid conflicts.

And Liang Xinran also stopped causing trouble for Liang Shi.

To be precise, the two stayed out of each other's way—well water not interfering with river water.¹

Also this spring, Liang Wanwan chose to study abroad.

Gu Yixue lazed around for the entire spring, saying she was polishing a script, but her new script was still nowhere in sight.

Everything was calm and peaceful.

Liang Shi would occasionally have meals with Zhao Xuning, occasionally bring wine to chat with Chen Mian, and occasionally stroll around Gu Yixue's studio.

Most of the time, she was rushing between the production set and home.

It was also this spring that Liang Shi decided to buy a house.

There happened to be a large flat-floor apartment for sale on the floor above them, so she bought it.

She didn't move directly into the house that Liang Xinzhou had given her.

The day of the move was a clear and sunny day. Liang Shi even invited Zhao Xuning and the others over for dinner.

Many people gathered at home. Under Sally's urging to drink, Liang Shi got completely drunk.

Somehow, Zhao Xuning also joined in the fun. Even though she had to be on duty the next day, she still got drunk with them, then slept on the floor for the night. When she woke up the next day, she was sneezing continuously.

Liang Shi was fine though. The next day, she could still get up to make hangover soup for her, while also trying to persuade her to skip work and not go to the hospital looking so sick—who knew if she was going there to be a doctor or to be admitted as a patient.

But Zhao Xuning remained unmoved, letting her words go in one ear and out the other—or perhaps they didn't even go in at all.

Xu Qingzhu was the most well-behaved. Even though they had changed residences, it didn't affect her much.

As a pregnant woman, she couldn't drink alcohol. Moreover, she was tired from packing the day before moving, so while they were still drinking, Xu Qingzhu was already so sleepy she couldn't keep her eyes open and went straight back to the room to sleep.

She didn't even know what time Liang Shi came back to the room.

When Xu Qingzhu got up and saw Zhao Xuning sneezing repeatedly and looking listless, she walked over to feel her forehead. But Zhao Xuning, who had her eyes lowered and looked dazed, suddenly grabbed her wrist.

Xu Qingzhu gasped.

Zhao Xuning immediately let go. "Sorry."

"It's fine." Xu Qingzhu even teased: "Good thing I've gained weight now. Otherwise, with my previous build, that grip would have snapped my bones."

Zhao Xuning pressed her temples and said nothing more.

But Xu Qingzhu said to her: "Dr. Zhao, you have a fever."

"Do I?" Zhao Xuning raised her hand to feel her own forehead.

"You can't tell by checking yourself." Xu Qingzhu went to look for a thermometer in the house, but since they had just moved, some miscellaneous items hadn't been unpacked yet and she couldn't find it at all. Zhao Xuning also told her not to bother—she had to go to the hospital soon anyway.

Liang Shi also came out and felt her forehead. "It does feel a bit hot."

She continued trying to persuade her not to go to the hospital, but Zhao Xuning didn't listen.

In the morning, Zhao Xuning left together with Chen Mian. Seeing her poor condition, Chen Mian dropped her off at the hospital entrance before going back to catch up on sleep.

While eating breakfast at home, Liang Shi chatted with Xu Qingzhu about last night. Gu Yixue had received a call after midnight and left by taxi.

Chen Mian, Zhao Xuning, Liang Shi, and Lin Luoxi drank until very late.

Although Sally kept clamoring to drink, her alcohol tolerance was average.

Not even as good as Lin Luoxi's.

Later, Zhao Ying had video-called Zhao Xuning and they chatted casually for a bit.

Afterward, Zhao Ying sent Zhao Xuning some message—no one knew what it said, but Zhao Xuning's expression changed after seeing it.

She started drinking like she was drinking water. If Liang Shi hadn't stopped her, she probably would have downed three bottles of baijiu² in a row.

Drinking until her stomach bled.

Xu Qingzhu shrugged: "It's probably related to Shen Hui."

"I think so too," Liang Shi said. "But what exactly happened?"

"Shen Hui's engagement date has been set," Xu Qingzhu said. "In half a month."

Liang Shi: "?"

"So sudden?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu didn't think so: "It's alright, I suppose. They've been talking about getting engaged since last year. Until now, it's been delayed for almost half a year. Maybe she was waiting for something."

Liang Shi: "Waiting for Zhao Xuning?"

Xu Qingzhu shook her head: "That I don't know."

Actually, they both knew it was ninety percent likely.

It's just that Zhao Xuning only took one step forward each time, then retreated at the slightest setback, not daring to move forward again. Whether she was afraid of Shen Hui or something else, no one knew.

1. "井水不犯河水" (well water doesn't interfere with river water) is a Chinese idiom meaning two parties stay out of each other's business and don't interfere with one another. ⇐
2. Baijiu (白酒) - A strong Chinese distilled spirit, typically clear in color and with an alcohol content usually between 40-60%. It's one of the most consumed spirits in the world and is commonly served at Chinese banquets and celebrations. ⇐

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All in all, she was just too timid.

Every time Liang Shi chatted with Xu Qingzhu about the old Zhao Xuning, she felt like it wasn't the same person as the current one.

The former Zhao Xuning was spirited, confident and proud. But the current Zhao Xuning was gloomy, like a soulless shell—waking up numbly each day, working numbly, sleeping numbly.

There wasn't a trace of the brilliance of a genius girl on her face, only an aura of impending death.

Even though Shen Hui said she had let her go.

And would no longer be entangled with her.

She still couldn't let herself go. Occasionally, she would go to Shen Hui's hospital to take a look, just standing outside the hospital smoking a cigarette, before going to work.

Once, when Liang Shi went to eat with her, they ran into Shen Hui and her girlfriend.

It should be the college classmate Zhao Xuning had mentioned before. She had proper looks and was quite considerate, always smiling at Shen Hui when she spoke. Liang Shi got the feeling she was somewhat flattering and insincere. Before leaving, she even came over specifically to greet Zhao Xuning, her words not very polite. Shen Hui just watched.

Liang Shi didn't really like that woman. She looked like she was approaching Shen Hui with some ulterior motive.

Later, Zhao Xuning said it was because that person's family didn't have much money. They used to run a company, but it went bankrupt when they were in college.

Looking so mercenary was probably because of this.

But most importantly, this person didn't have much genuine feelings for Shen Hui.

Liang Shi urged Zhao Xuning to go and make Shen Hui stay, but Zhao Xuning walked to the doorway, stared at the two figures until they disappeared, smoked a cigarette, and went back inside.

Liang Shi cursed her for being too cowardly.

Zhao Xuning only curved her lips slightly without saying anything.

At that moment, Zhao Xuning's eyes were red, with tears, and an emotion called fear.

Later, one day Zhao Xuning was drinking away her sorrows at a bar. After getting drunk, she said something to Liang Shi.

She said: "Only now do I know I love her too much. So I'm afraid she won't be doing well without me, and even more afraid that she's not doing well."

Zhao Xuning's voice was hoarse. She told Liang Shi: "I could go and make her stay, but would that be the right thing to do? What if we repeat our old mistakes? I'm afraid of seeing her disgust. I'm even more afraid that I'll keep her, but won't be able to give her happiness."

Out of ten thousand reconciliations, nine thousand nine hundred end up repeating the same mistakes.

Zhao Xuning didn't dare to gamble.

Didn't dare to try to make her stay.

After that time, Liang Shi never dared to mention anything related to Shen Hui again.

No matter how miserable Zhao Xuning felt, she absolutely refused to use Shen Hui's name to provoke or hurt her.

That was Zhao Xuning's true soft spot.

To be loved so stubbornly by someone could also be considered a kind of fortune.

Now, Shen Hui was getting engaged—things were about to be settled.

Liang Shi felt quite emotional after hearing this.

But she and Xu Qingzhu were both outsiders, powerless to do anything about it.

However, Liang Shi had an interview that day. During a break in the middle of the interview, she heard some staff members discussing: "What the hell? What kind of grudge is this? She's actually kneeling her way up three thousand steps?"

"I'm not saying anything, but are young people these days really this dramatic when dating?"

"The key is she's so good-looking. Why hang herself on one tree?"¹

"What do you mean? I heard these two broke up. Now one of them is getting engaged and was on the mountain with her fiancée to enjoy the scenery. Then the ex-girlfriend showed up saying she couldn't get engaged or something. The other woman got angry and said if she could kneel and bow her way up all three thousand steps to Huichang Temple at the mountaintop today, she wouldn't get engaged."

"That's a thing? What kind of pitiful ex-girlfriend is this?"

"If she were ugly, I'd curse her for bringing it on herself. But she's so good-looking, and she's wearing a white coat. I... feel like I'm watching a xianxia drama."²

"Someone dug up that this is Zhao Ying's cousin!"

"What? No way? Her ex-girlfriend is a goddess? She has to do this?"

"Who knows with matters of the heart? But honestly, the way she kneels and climbs step by step, she looks so shattered. It breaks my heart watching it."

"People online really think she's filming a drama, not trying to win back her ex-girlfriend. They just can't see any cameras, hahaha."

"....."

Everyone was discussing enthusiastically. It was evening, with crimson clouds spreading across the horizon. Liang Shi caught the words "Zhao Ying's cousin"—wasn't that Zhao Xuning?

She then asked her assistant for her phone. There were no messages.

But there was a trending topic on hot search: #Zhao Ying's Cousin Three Thousand Steps#.

"Three thousand steps" was actually an exaggeration. There was a mountain on the outskirts of Haizhou City with Huichang Temple on top. It was said to be especially effective for praying for marriage and children. Most people took the cable car from the foot of the mountain to Huichang Temple at the top, but there was a mountain path with over two thousand steps according to incomplete statistics, jokingly called the "Three Thousand Steps."

In the past, some people had walked the three thousand steps with a bow at each step, mostly praying for blessings for their children.

In recent years, everyone was used to taking the cable car—they couldn't even be bothered to walk up, let alone kneel and bow with each step.

Liang Shi saw Zhao Xuning's photos online. Her clean white coat was stained with dust. When she left Liang Shi's home this morning, she was wearing black high-waisted wide-leg pants with a white shirt on top—almost her unchanging look throughout the year.

Her light brown straight hair was tied in a low ponytail, casually put up without any aesthetic appeal to speak of.

But her face would add glory to anything.

Even the most ordinary clothes looked beautiful on her.

The most circulated content online was a video of about ten seconds.

Zhao Xuning's complexion was somewhat pale. She didn't look at the path ahead, just woodenly and devoutly bowing, her forehead also dirty. A few strands of hair hung by her face. It was truly one step, one bow—every movement was very standard.

Originally, climbing three thousand steps with a bow at each step wouldn't be such a big deal.

But Zhao Xuning was too good-looking, plus today was Huichang Temple's annual temple celebration, so there were many people from all over the country.

At first, people thought they were filming a drama, but later discovered there were no cameras.

Combined with the fact that someone had seen Zhao Xuning arguing with Shen Hui, that's what led to everything after.

At first, it was just a topic about a devoted woman trying to win back her girlfriend. Later, someone discovered this person had posted a photo with Zhao Ying on Weibo before—she was Zhao Ying's doctor cousin.

There are no secrets on the internet.

And so Zhao Xuning ended up on hot search.

Even though it was under Zhao Ying's famous name.

Liang Shi stared at that video and watched it three times. Zhao Xuning's complexion in the video looked very wrong. She already had a slight fever when she left her home this morning—how could she possibly endure this?

Liang Shi sent Xu Qingzhu a message: [Did you see the hot search? Zhao Xuning.]

Xu Qingzhu replied after a while: [Just finished a meeting. What happened?]

Liang Shi: [...She's gone crazy.]

There was no other explanation besides going crazy.

Xu Qingzhu also finished reading the hot search and sent her a screen full of ellipses.

Liang Shi forwarded the video that netizens posted to Xu Qingzhu: [She's probably still running a fever. If she rolls down the steps later... that would be a tragedy.]

Xu Qingzhu: [Forget it, I'll go find her.]

Liang Shi: [Don't. She's already climbed so high. Don't tire yourself out. I'll go. I'm almost done here.]

Xu Qingzhu: [I'll try calling her.]

After a while, Xu Qingzhu said again: [Can't get through.]

Liang Shi also tried to contact Zhao Xuning, but the call really couldn't get through.

The interview here still needed to be wrapped up. Liang Shi urged the staff to cut two questions and finished the interview as quickly as possible. As soon as the interview ended, she immediately ran out and drove to the outskirts of the city.

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1. "在一棵樹上吊死" (hang oneself on one tree) is a Chinese idiom meaning to stubbornly fixate on one option or person when there are other possibilities, similar to "putting all your eggs in one basket" in terms of romantic pursuits. ↵
 2. Xianxia (仙俠) - A genre of Chinese fantasy involving immortals, martial arts, and cultivation. These dramas often feature dramatic scenes of devotion and sacrifice for love. ↵

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Meanwhile, at the outskirts of the city, Shen Hui and Wu Li stood at the foot of the mountain.

People came and went around them, and quite a few were already heading down the mountain.

People passing by were all talking about the person they had just encountered, saying she was too beautiful.

They also chatted about how this person had made it onto the hot search, climbing the three thousand steps to win back her ex-girlfriend.

Wu Li stood to the side, looking somewhat at a loss. Shen Hui neither spoke nor moved. Ever since Zhao Xuning started kneeling her way up the three thousand steps, she had maintained this posture, completely motionless.

Like a statue.

Finally, Wu Li couldn't hold back. "A-Hui, we're getting engaged next week, right?"

Shen Hui looked at her and pressed her lips together: "Not necessarily?"

Her tone was slow and light, with a hint of hoarseness.

"You're not really going to... because of Zhao Xuning..." Wu Li was stunned and smiled bitterly. "Have you two been connected all along?"¹

Shen Hui shook her head: "We haven't been in contact for a long time."

"Then you?" Wu Li frowned. "You're not really going to believe what she said, are you? I really didn't deceive you, I..."

"I have my own judgment." Shen Hui stood straight with her hands in her pockets. "I don't just believe things because she says a few words."

Wu Li anxiously tried to explain. "We've been together for half a year. You should know what kind of person I am, right?"

"I know," Shen Hui said. "You might be able to deceive me, but Zhao Xuning..."

She paused. "...would never lie about something like this."

Zhao Xuning said Wu Li couldn't be married. She said what Wu Li did wrong was something unforgivable.

Although she didn't specify what exactly it was.

If she didn't have one hundred percent evidence, Zhao Xuning wouldn't slander someone like this.

That was Zhao Xuning.

The stubborn, obstinate, unruly Zhao Xuning who always had high moral standards.

Shen Hui heard people nearby talking about Zhao Xuning making it onto the hot search. Before long, several cars stopped at the foot of the mountain. A large group of bodyguards appeared, and a lavishly dressed woman appeared at the foot of the mountain. Her face bore some resemblance to Zhao Xuning's.

Shen Hui still stood motionless.

Soon, all the hot search topics online were taken down. Then Shen Hui received a call from Shen Fenghe. "Where are you?"

"At the foot of the mountain," Shen Hui said. "I was originally just here to clear my head."

"Come home," Shen Fenghe said. "If you don't want to be entangled with Zhao Xuning anymore."

Shen Hui looked at the endless three thousand steps and smiled bitterly: "It seems I'm destined to be entangled with her."

There was a pause on Shen Fenghe's end, and she didn't speak for a long while.

"Have you thought it through?" Shen Fenghe asked.

Shen Hui exhaled softly, her laugh carrying a choked quality: "Sis, she's climbing the three thousand steps for me."

Shen Fenghe was taken aback: "I know."

"She." Shen Hui paused, a tear sliding down her cheek as she spoke in a choked voice: "She's bowing her head to me."

Shen Fenghe coughed lightly: "And? You're Shen Hui. Shouldn't she bow her head to you? How many times have you swallowed your pride for her?"

Shen Hui's voice was very soft, mingling with the evening spring breeze: "She once said that climbing the three thousand steps with a bow at each step was something she would never do even if she died."

"So?" Shen Fenghe's voice also softened.

Shen Hui thought for a moment: "I'll wait for her at the top of the mountain."

"What about your marriage to Wu Li?" Shen Fenghe asked.

Shen Hui glanced at Wu Li standing beside her: "Cancel it."

Cold and merciless.

As if she wasn't the one who had been dating these past few months.

Indeed, it couldn't really be called dating.

Even though they were at the same hospital, they didn't see each other three times a week. Wu Li still didn't know where her home was. They ate together once a month, and Wu Li had only met her family last week.

Rather than saying they were getting married, it was more like she was truly seeking a way to let herself go.

But she found that neither way was easy.

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1. "藕斷絲連" (the lotus root is severed but the threads remain connected) is a Chinese idiom describing a relationship that has officially ended but emotional ties still remain, like when ex-lovers can't completely let go of each other. ⇐

Chapter 174-6

When dreams came at midnight, she still thought of Zhao Xuning. The occasional phantom that appeared when passing by the university campus was still Zhao Xuning.

Day and night, she punished herself. Day and night, she couldn't let go, couldn't move on.

Such days left Shen Hui utterly exhausted.

She always wanted to find a sunny, peaceful day to end this exhausting life.

Yet she lacked the courage to stake everything on one throw.

After Shen Hui hung up the phone, she saw the lavishly dressed noblewoman walking toward her, her high heels striking the ground with resounding clicks.

Shen Hui met her gaze with neither servility nor arrogance.

"You're Shen Hui?" the other party asked.

Shen Hui nodded: "That's me."

"I'm Zhao Xuning's mother." The other party introduced herself: "Did you know she's on the hot search?"

"I just heard about it," Shen Hui replied.

Her tone was bland. She didn't put on a pleasant expression just because the other party was Zhao Xuning's mother—she remained cold.

Mother Zhao froze. She was already angry, and now her temper flared even more at Shen Hui's tone.

"You made her kneel her way up three thousand steps? Are you crazy?" Mother Zhao said angrily. "From childhood to adulthood, aside from kneeling during ancestral worship on holidays, when has she ever knelt? She dates you and loses half her life in the process. Where's my spirited daughter from before? Isn't that enough yet? Do you want to torment her to death?!"

Hearing this, Shen Hui's eyes swept over her indifferently, her voice slowing: "She chose to do it herself."

"Would she have done this if not for you?" Mother Zhao said coldly. "Ever since she met you, she's gone crazy. You've nearly driven her mad."

Shen Hui curved her lips into a light smile, not knowing who had caused her own transformation over these years.

The formerly lofty Second Miss of the Shen family, who looked down on everyone—she too had become meek and submissive for Zhao Xuning.

Shen Hui's smile widened on her face as she said indifferently: "Whatever."

After all, they had gone crazy together.

Bound together for this lifetime—let them be crazy then.

Mother Zhao's eyes immediately widened. Furious, she raised her hand to slap her, but her arm was blocked. A clear, youthful voice rang out: "Are you crazy?"

A tall figure immediately blocked Shen Hui, shielding her completely.

"A-Yan," Shen Hui called out to him softly.

But Shen Siyan, who had run over sweating profusely, frowned and stared coldly at the person opposite. "No one has ever hit my sister in her entire life. If you actually lay a hand on her, I don't care who you are—you can say goodbye to that arm."

When Liang Shi arrived, this was exactly what she heard.

Then she heard Shen Siyan continue: "I don't care how your Zhao Xuning goes crazy. The girls of our Shen family are all raised as treasures in the palm of our hands. Try touching a single hair on her."

Mother Zhao froze, then laughed angrily: "What big talk."

"If you don't believe it, feel free to try." Shen Siyan stared at her coldly. "Hasn't the Zhao family's business been doing poorly lately? Didn't your cooperation with Hejing fall through?"

Mother Zhao was stunned: "How do you know?"

Shen Siyan curved his lips into a cold smile: "Because I'm the one who did it, of course."

Hearing this, Shen Hui pinched his arm. "A-Yan, stop talking."

Shen Siyan patted her hand reassuringly. "Second Sister, it's fine. Don't be scared."

Shen Hui's brows furrowed slightly.

Shen Siyan looked at Mother Zhao and continued: "This is just a small punishment. If it were my eldest sister or my father standing here today, the Zhao family could really be waiting for bankruptcy. The way you treated my second sister back then—the Zhao family will pay the corresponding price."

Mother Zhao frowned: "Who are you people?"

Seeing that they were about to have a full-blown argument, Liang Shi immediately stepped forward and called out: "Shen Hui."

She directly inserted herself between Mother Zhao and Shen Siyan.

Shen Siyan frowned slightly but said nothing.

Liang Shi looked at Mother Zhao and said gently: "Auntie, I'm Zhao Xuning's friend. This is her choice. You... let's just wait for her quietly."

The implication was—stop causing trouble. Zhao Xuning wouldn't want to see this.

Someone who had to kneel her way up three thousand steps to win her back—don't let her mother ruin it with a few careless words.

It was tragic enough to make even ghosts cry.

Liang Shi could only help minimize the damage for Zhao Xuning.

Mother Zhao was unwilling, but she also understood her daughter's situation. So she sent people up to find Zhao Xuning, while Shen Hui and Shen Siyan took the cable car up the mountain.

Liang Shi took the steps.

Walking was still faster than kneeling and bowing with each step. However, Zhao Xuning was also moving quite fast and had already completed half.

Liang Shi had a hard time catching up to her.

When she finally caught up, Zhao Xuning's forehead was already bruised from the kowtowing, her lips cracked, her complexion deathly pale. Two bodyguards in black were beside her trying to persuade her to go down, but Zhao Xuning told them to get lost. She persisted unwaveringly, kneeling and bowing with standard movements as she climbed.

Liang Shi couldn't say anything either. She just handed her a bottle of water when she stood up.

Zhao Xuning closed her eyes briefly, sweat dripping from her forehead, and continued upward.